

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

The World Health Organisation declared an **Ebola** outbreak in Congo and Uganda a “public-health emergency of international concern”. The UN health agency said [the virus](#) was suspected of infecting 250 people and killing 80 in regions along the border between the two countries. It called for greater “co-ordination and co-operation”, but said the outbreak was not yet a “pandemic emergency”.

The **United Arab Emirates** said a drone struck its Barakah nuclear power plant, causing a fire. Radiation levels remain safe and no one was injured. Officials are investigating the source of the drone. Since the Gulf war began **Iran** has launched almost 3,000 drones and missiles at the UAE; Emirati officials say some have targeted energy infrastructure.

Volodymyr Zelensky, **Ukraine’s** president, said his country’s latest wave of drone strikes, which killed three people in the Moscow region, was “entirely justified”. It appeared to be Ukraine’s biggest such operation since the start of the war. **Russia** said it intercepted more than 500 drones across 14 regions and occupied Crimea. Mr Zelensky cited a Russian assault on Kyiv, Ukraine’s capital, on Thursday that killed 24 people.

[Andy Burnham](#), Greater Manchester's mayor, said he was “not advocating” for **Britain** to rejoin the European Union after [Wes Streeting](#), who resigned as health secretary on Thursday, declared Brexit a “catastrophic mistake”. Both men have signalled they would stand in any Labour leadership contest. Sir Keir Starmer's prime ministership is [on the brink](#) after more than 90 MPs called for his resignation.

Bill Cassidy, a Republican senator from Louisiana who voted to convict **Donald Trump** in his impeachment trial in 2021, was beaten in a party primary. Mr Trump had targeted Mr Cassidy, endorsing Julia Letlow, a congresswoman, who came top. She faces a run-off against John Fleming, the state treasurer, for the nomination. The result illustrates Mr Trump's [tight grip](#) on the Republican Party, even as his [approval rating](#) weakens.

Israel launched strikes on a town in southern **Lebanon**, hours after the two countries agreed to extend their ceasefire. Lebanese officials said six people were killed in the attack. Israel claimed it had targeted members of [Hizbullah](#). Separately, an Israeli air strike in Gaza on Friday killed Izz al-Din al-Haddad, the commander of Hamas's armed wing, who was said to have been an architect of the October 7th attacks.

Tata Electronics, an Indian tech firm, and ASML, a Dutch supplier of chipmaking equipment, signed an agreement to collaborate on building **India's** first commercial **semiconductor** fabrication plant. Tata plans to invest \$11bn in [the factory](#) in the western state of Gujarat. India is desperate to strengthen its chipmaking capabilities and has offered billions of dollars in subsidies to attract investment.

Word of the week: *Darshan*, sight. [Read our obituary](#) of Raghu Rai, India's most famous photojournalist, who used his to recognise the connection between all things.



Photograph: Reuters

A whirlwind week in Philippine politics

On Monday the Philippines' House of Representatives [impeached Sara Duterte](#), the country's vice-president (and daughter of a former strongman president). Two days later her allies holed up in the Senate, claiming to be under siege by government law-enforcers. Shots were heard inside. Still, the whole affair smells of a manufactured crisis. The Senate's own forces may have started the shooting. (They report to Alan Peter Cayetano, a pro-Duterte senator who managed to unseat the previous Senate president just before the vice-president's impeachment.) The chaos has diverted some attention from Ms Duterte's forthcoming impeachment trial in the Senate.

Mr Cayetano has said that senators will still meet this coming Monday to discuss the rules for the trial. If convicted, Ms Duterte will be barred from holding office and unable to run for president in 2028. If acquitted, she will be favourite to win that election. That would return power to a dynasty built on violence and the politics of revenge.

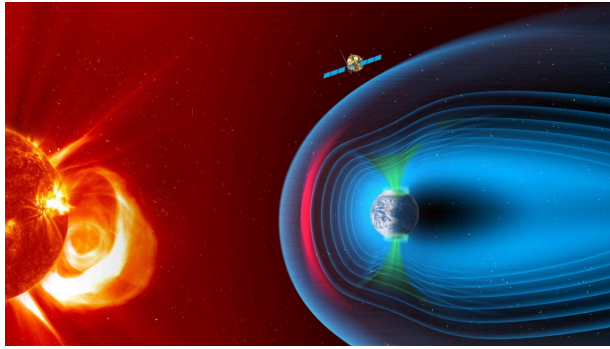


Photograph: Getty Images

A closely watched vote in Spain

All of Spain will be watching when Andalucíans vote in local elections on Sunday. The country's most populous region is the last to go to the polls before the next general election, due by August 2027 at the latest. Polling indicates that Juan Manuel Moreno, the affable local leader of the centre-right People's Party, and regional president since 2019, has a strong chance of retaining his narrow majority. This would spare him from having to enter a painful negotiation with Vox, of the populist right.

It spells bad news for [Pedro Sánchez](#), Spain's prime minister. His Socialists look set to be thrashed in what was traditionally a stronghold. The party's candidate in Andalucía, María Jesús Montero, was Mr Sánchez's finance minister and deputy prime minister. If, as polling suggests, the Socialists suffer their worst-ever result in Andalucía, the rebuff to Mr Sánchez would be further evidence that Spain is moving to the right.



Photograph: ESA/ATG medialab

Geomagnetic storm chasing

SMILE, a joint European-Chinese satellite to be launched next week, will provide global 3D coverage of the Earth unlike any seen before. Its pictures will not be of the Earth's surface but of its magnetosphere—the region around the planet in which its magnetic field traps charged particles. And rather than being made using visible light, the pictures will record what is to be seen in the x-ray and ultraviolet regions of the spectrum.

The idea is to better understand interactions between the magnetosphere and the “solar wind” of charged particles emitted by the Sun. SMILE's camera will look at the area where the wind and the magnetosphere meet head on and at the regions that produce the auroras seen in the Arctic and Antarctic. The images should help scientists understand what happens when the solar wind gets frisky, producing storms in the magnetosphere which knock out power grids. With any luck they will be pretty, too.

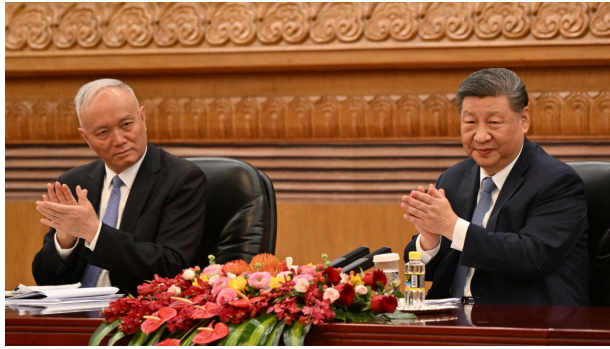


Photograph: Neon

A real work of art

Their plan is foolproof. The greedy children of Julian Sklar, a once-famous painter, hire Lori (Michaela Coel), a young artist, to pose as his assistant. Her real job? To forge the last series of his renowned paintings, “The Christophers”, which they will sell for a fortune after he dies. But Julian, played by a witty Sir Ian McKellen, is too nosy and clever to let them get away with it.

“The Christophers”, released in cinemas in Britain this weekend, is an elegant portrayal of inheritance and artistic taste. Steven Soderbergh, the director, is best known for heist capers such as “Ocean’s Eleven”. Yet this film stands out for its rich dialogue, not action sequences. Thanks in part to the chemistry between Sir Ian and Ms Coel, amusing moments give way to reflections on ageing and legacy. For all its talk of forgery, this film is the real deal.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Cai Qi, China's second-most powerful man

In some photos of this week's meeting between Xi Jinping and Donald Trump, you can spot a tall, white-haired figure sitting to the right of the Chinese president. [Cai Qi](#) may be the second-most powerful person in China. As Mr Xi's right-hand man, in functional terms as well as seating plans, Mr Cai has insight into almost every area of policy and access to many of the Communist Party's secrets.

As chief of the party's powerful General Office, Mr Cai acts as Mr Xi's chief of staff, controlling his schedule and the people and information that reach him. But he also runs the body that implements leadership decisions and manages the party apparatus, and leads another that controls Mr Xi's personal security. Sometimes he even supervises Mr Xi's medical care.

The breadth and depth of Mr Cai's responsibilities is highly unusual. "Whenever people ask me, 'What happens if Xi were to drop dead tomorrow and there was no succession plan, who would get the top job?', Cai Qi seems like the obvious answer," says Jonathan Czin, a former China analyst at the CIA.

Born in the eastern province of Fujian in 1955, Mr Cai was sent to work in the countryside as a teenager, like Mr Xi, during the Cultural Revolution that raged across China between 1966 and

1976. When Mr Xi was posted to Fujian in 1985, Mr Cai was a junior official there. He later spent some 15 years working closely with Mr Xi in Fujian and neighbouring Zhejiang province.

His big break came in 2014 when Mr Xi brought him to Beijing to join the National Security Commission, a secretive body believed to include spies, generals and police chiefs. Within three years, Mr Cai was elevated to the Politburo, the party's top 25 leaders, despite not having previously been in the broader Central Committee. He then became mayor and later party chief of Beijing, where he appears to have impressed Mr Xi. He was also an energetic advocate of absolute loyalty to China's leader. That helps to explain his unusual appointment in 2023 to lead the General Office soon after joining the Politburo Standing Committee.

All of that suggests that the president values him as a hard-nosed enforcer and administrator. More importantly, he is not seen as a threat, as his swift promotion from relative obscurity means he does not have his own political powerbase. Instead, he derives his authority entirely through his relationship with Mr Xi.

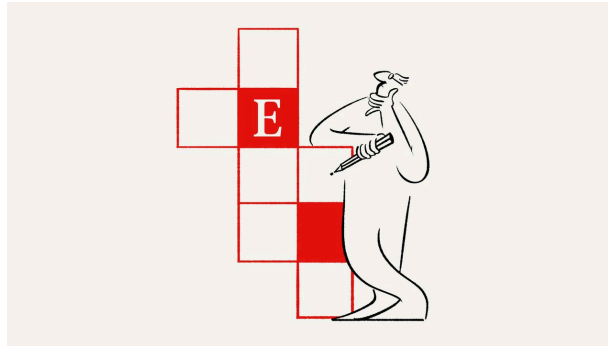


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Flat, even if you spell it backwards (5)

2 across - Laura confused hearing (5)

3 across - Minor thought: what's my point? (5)

1 down - Tacit loan wiped out for milk production (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Flush; a stage in a computer game (5)

2 across - Relating to the ear or the sense of hearing (5)

3 across - Boreal, “up” on a map usually (5)

1 down - The process of producing and secreting milk (9)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Yu Zhang, Mosman, Australia

Ayako Fukui, Singapore

Erik Mashkilleyson, Helsinki, Finland

They gave the correct answers of Leonardo da Vinci, Bill Clinton, Babe Ruth, Albert Einstein and Sir Paul McCartney. The theme is that they are all left-handed.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Renaissance artist had a sideline as a military engineer for Cesare Borgia?

Tuesday: Which American president was born in a town called Hope?

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Friday: Which musician sang a duet with Stevie Wonder called “Ebony and Ivory”?

*You must write, and read, as if
your life depended on it.*

Andrienne Rich